

Narrative Drift

When Explanations Remain Coherent After Losing the Ability to Be Corrected by Events

A. Jacobs | Reality Drift Framework

Framework Context

Reality Drift describes the progressive loss of corrective contact between a system's representations and the real-world conditions they are meant to track, explain, or affect, even while the system remains functional and internally coherent. Narrative Drift is the interpretive expression of that broader pattern.

Canonical Definition

Narrative Drift is the progressive loss of corrective contact between an explanatory account and the events, evidence, or causal conditions it claims to describe. The narrative remains coherent, persuasive, and authoritative, but contradictory evidence is reframed, absorbed, or excluded rather than allowed to revise the account. The explanation survives by becoming increasingly self-referential.

What Is Drifting

Referent

Events, evidence, causal relations, lived conditions, and outcomes that an explanation is meant to organize.

Operational representation

Stories, frames, interpretations, talking points, summaries, causal models, and explanatory language.

Selection pressure

Accounts are rewarded for coherence, familiarity, persuasion, identity compatibility, and institutional usefulness.

Weak correction

Contradictory evidence is redescribed through the existing account, denied standing, or detached from its provenance.

Representational Mechanism

Coherence preservation: The account is revised at its edges so its central explanatory structure does not have to change.

Retrospective fitting: Events are reorganized after the fact to make the existing narrative appear continuously adequate.

Recursive Compression: Prior summaries and interpretations become inputs to later accounts, carrying earlier omissions forward.

Synthetic coherence: Language becomes more complete, polished, and certain while its evidentiary path becomes less reconstructable.

Feedback insulation: Evidence can circulate without acquiring enough authority to change the narrative.

Narrative absorption: Contradiction becomes new material for explaining why the original account remains correct.

Recognition Signs

- The same explanation survives substantially different outcomes.
- Disconfirming evidence changes the wording but not the underlying model.
- Later summaries cite earlier summaries until the source event becomes difficult to reconstruct.
- Uncertainty decreases as distance from direct evidence increases.
- Competing accounts become identity markers rather than revisable descriptions.
- The narrative helps determine what is measured, and the resulting measurements are then used to validate the narrative.

How Correction Weakens

Narrative Drift becomes self-reinforcing when a narrative influences classification, attention, measurement, and institutional action. Those actions can alter the environment, and the changed environment is then interpreted through the same categories and treated as independent confirmation.

The system no longer merely explains events. It begins helping produce the conditions it later cites as evidence. Coherence can therefore increase even as corrective contact weakens.

Cross-Domain Examples

Media

New events are fitted into an established storyline while developments that would require a different model receive less visibility or explanatory weight.

Corporate communication

Strategic explanations remain stable while declining performance is redescribed as transition, investment, restructuring, or temporary friction.

Politics

The same causal account can be preserved across incompatible outcomes by changing which events are treated as relevant or explanatory.

Institutions

Official explanations shape reporting categories, and the resulting reports later appear to confirm the explanation that helped produce them.

AI systems

Fluent generated accounts can combine inherited summaries into persuasive explanations without preserving a reliable path back to the original source conditions.

Boundary and Distinctions

Narrative Drift is not synonymous with falsehood, bias, propaganda, disagreement, or ordinary reinterpretation. An inaccurate narrative can remain open to correction.

Drift begins when the narrative determines how contradiction itself will be classified, allowing the explanation to survive evidence that should have revised it. Narrative Drift can therefore occur without deliberate deception.

Relationship to Reality Drift

Narrative Drift is an interpretive pathway within Reality Drift. It turns partial outputs from the Representation Stack into a stable account of what happened and why.

When that account becomes less answerable to its referent, it can preserve Institutional Drift, conceal Mission Drift, and erase the sequence required to detect Temporal Drift.

Compact Diagnostic

1. What events or conditions is this narrative supposed to explain?
2. Which evidence could genuinely force the account to change?
3. Can the original sources and transformations behind the explanation be reconstructed?
4. Does contradiction revise the model or become further support for it?
5. Has the narrative helped create the environment later offered as confirmation?

The absence of failure is not proof of alignment. Coherence is not contact.